PRIMARY TEACHING NOTES — INDUCTION SERIES

Lesson Planning for Primary Teachers

How to plan a period before you teach it: student learning outcomes, step-by-step timing, three complete worked examples, and ready-to-use daily and weekly formats.

By Shah Fahad

Primary School Teacher (PST), ESED Khyber Pakhtunkhwa

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About this note. This is one note in a series for primary teachers, based on the topics covered in the induction programme for newly appointed PSTs. Each note covers one topic on its own. This one is only about lesson planning: what a plan contains, how to build one, and what a finished plan looks like for English, Mathematics and Science.

Why Planning Matters, and What a Plan Contains

Why plan at all?

A lesson plan is a short written answer to four questions, decided before the period starts: What will the students learn? How will I teach it? What do I need? How will I know they learned it? A teacher who has answered these on paper walks in calm, uses the full period, and does not discover halfway through that the flashcards are in another room or that the topic needs two periods, not one.

- **Time is protected.** Steps have minutes, so the practice and checking at the end are not squeezed out by a long introduction.
- **Materials are ready.** Charts, flashcards, real objects and copies are listed and collected before the bell.
- **Every child is included.** The plan names an easy task for slow learners and an extra task for fast finishers in advance.
- **The record exists.** If a substitute teacher takes the class, the plan shows where the class has reached.

The parts of a good lesson plan

Part	What it says
Class, subject, topic, date	Which class, which subject, the exact topic from the textbook, and the period's date and time.
Student Learning Outcomes (SLOs)	What students will be able to do by the end, written with an action word: read, identify, add, label, explain. Usually one or two per period.
Prior knowledge	What the class already knows that this lesson builds on, and the two or three questions you will ask to check it.
Resources / teaching aids	Textbook pages, board work, flashcards, charts, real objects, worksheets — everything the steps will use.
Steps with timings	Introduction, presentation, guided practice, independent practice, assessment and closure, each with its minutes.
Assessment	How you will check the SLO: oral questions, a short written task, an exit question, observation during practice.
Homework and reflection	A short task linked to the SLO, plus two lines written after the period: what worked, what to change next time.

> **Good SLO vs weak SLO.** Weak: "Students will understand addition." Nobody can see understanding. Good: "Students will add two 3-digit numbers with carrying, correctly, in at least 4 out of 5 sums." The second can be checked, so it can be planned for.

Building a Plan, Step by Step

1. **Read the textbook first.** Teach the period yourself, in your head. Note the difficult words, the example that explains best, and where students usually make mistakes.
2. **Write the SLOs.** One or two only, each starting with an action word and each checkable at the end of the period.
3. **Decide the checking first.** Fix the end-of-period questions or task before writing the middle steps. Teaching then aims at a known target.
4. **Plan the opening.** Two or three questions on prior knowledge, or a real object, picture or short story that connects the new topic to what students already know.
5. **Plan the presentation in small steps.** New learning in two or three small pieces, each followed by a quick question, never one long lecture.
6. **Plan guided, then independent practice.** First examples solved together on the board, then students working alone while you move around the class.
7. **Add the support and challenge tasks.** One simpler version for students who are stuck, one extra question for those who finish early.
8. **Close the loop.** A two-minute summary by the students themselves, the exit check, and short homework that repeats today's SLO — not new work.

How a 40-minute period divides

Step	Minutes	What happens
Introduction	5	Settle the class, check prior knowledge, state today's topic and outcome in simple words.
Presentation	10	Teach the new content in small steps, with board work, a chart or a real object, and quick questions after each step.
Guided practice	8	Work examples together. Students answer, come to the board, and correct mistakes as a class.
Independent practice	10	Students work alone or in pairs from the book or a worksheet. The teacher moves, helps and observes.
Assessment	4	The planned check: two or three questions or one short task matched exactly to the SLO.
Closure and homework	3	Students summarise in their own words. Homework is given, written on the board and explained.

> **For a 35-minute period,** take 2 minutes from presentation and 3 from practice. Never cut assessment or closure — they tell you whether the lesson worked.

Worked Example 1 — English, Class 3

Class: 3 **Subject:** English **Topic:** Reading — "My Family" (textbook reading passage) **Period:** 35 minutes

SLOs: By the end of the period, students will (1) read the passage aloud with correct pronunciation of the new words, and (2) answer three questions about the passage in complete sentences.

Prior knowledge: Students know family words in their home language and the English words mother, father, brother, sister from Class 2.

Resources: Textbook, word flashcards (family, parents, elder, younger, kind), a family picture chart, board and chalk/markers.

Step	Time	Teacher and student activity
Introduction	4 min	Show the family picture chart. Ask: Who is in your family? How many brothers and sisters do you have? Write two answers on the board. Tell the class: today we read about a family in English.
New words	5 min	Show each flashcard, say the word, class repeats twice, one student uses it in a short sentence. Stick the cards on the board for the whole period.
Reading	10 min	Teacher reads the passage aloud once, with expression. Then choral reading: class reads each sentence after the teacher. Then three confident students read one paragraph each.
Guided practice	7 min	Ask the three textbook questions orally. Students find answers in the passage, raise hands, and answer in complete sentences. Correct gently and write the best answers on the board.
Independent practice	6 min	Students copy and complete in notebooks: "My father's name is ____. I have ____ brother(s) and ____ sister(s)." Teacher moves and helps slow writers.
Assessment and closure	3 min	Exit check: point to two flashcards — students say the word and its meaning. Two students summarise the passage in one sentence each.

Support task: slow learners copy the two board answers and read them aloud with a partner. **Challenge task:** fast finishers write one extra sentence about their own family. **Homework:** read the passage to a family member and write the new words twice in the notebook.

Worked Example 2 — Mathematics, Class 4

Class: 4 **Subject:** Mathematics **Topic:** Addition of 3-digit numbers with carrying **Period:** 40 minutes

SLOs: By the end of the period, students will add two 3-digit numbers with carrying, correctly, in at least 4 out of 5 sums.

Prior knowledge: Students can add 2-digit numbers with carrying and know place value — ones, tens and hundreds.

Resources: Textbook exercise, place-value chart, bundle of sticks or straws in tens, board, notebooks.

Step	Time	Teacher and student activity
Introduction	5 min	Two quick 2-digit sums on the board from the last lesson. Then a real question: the school has 268 boys and 175 girls — how many students in total? Tell the class: today we learn to add bigger numbers.
Presentation	10 min	Solve 268 + 175 on the place-value chart, column by column: ones first, carry the ten, then tens, carry the hundred, then hundreds. Solve one more sum (347 + 286) with students calling out each step.
Guided practice	8 min	Two sums on the board. Volunteers solve one column each while the class checks. Correct the common mistake: forgetting to add the carried number.
Independent practice	11 min	Five sums from the textbook exercise in notebooks. Teacher circulates, watches the carrying step, and notes who needs help.
Assessment	4 min	One fresh sum (459 + 278) solved by every student and shown to the teacher — this checks the SLO directly.
Closure and homework	2 min	A student states the rule in simple words: start from the ones, carry when a column passes nine. Homework: four sums from the exercise.

Support task: students who are stuck use stick bundles to make the carry physical — ten loose sticks exchanged for one bundle of ten. **Challenge task:** add three 3-digit numbers, or write a word problem for a partner.

> **Why practice is longest here.** Mathematics is a skill subject: students learn it by doing, not by listening. Presentation stays short, and watched practice takes the biggest share of the period.

Worked Example 3 — Science, Class 5

Class: 5 **Subject:** General Science **Topic:** Parts of a plant and their jobs **Period:** 40 minutes

SLOs: By the end of the period, students will (1) name the main parts of a plant — root, stem, leaf, flower, fruit — and (2) state one job of each part.

Prior knowledge: Students see plants daily at home and in fields, and can name a tree, a leaf and a flower in their home language.

Resources: One whole small plant with roots (pulled gently from soft soil), a labelled chart, textbook diagram, notebooks. Plan the plant a day ahead — this lesson cannot be collected at the last minute.

Step	Time	Teacher and student activity
Introduction	5 min	Hold up the real plant. Ask: what do you see? Students name parts freely. Tell the class: today we learn the scientific names and what each part does for the plant.
Presentation	11 min	Pass the plant around row by row. For each part: point, name it, state its job in one sentence — roots take in water and hold the plant; stem carries water and holds the plant up; leaves make food; flowers make seeds and fruit. Match each part to the chart.
Guided practice	8 min	Students draw the plant in notebooks and label the parts with the teacher, following the chart. Teacher checks labels desk by desk.
Independent practice	9 min	In pairs: one student names a part, the other says its job, then they change roles. Then each student writes the five parts and their jobs in a two-column table.
Assessment	5 min	Point to parts of the real plant without naming them: students name the part and its job. Five students answer — a direct check of both SLOs.
Closure and homework	2 min	Class chants the summary together: part — job, part — job. Homework: draw and label a plant found at home.

Safety and care: wash hands after handling soil and plants; use a common plant, never a poisonous one; return the plant to soil or water after the lesson if it can live. **Support task:** label only three parts. **Challenge task:** add one part not on the chart, such as a bud or a thorn, and guess its job.

Daily and Weekly Plan Formats

Two formats cover almost all planning a primary teacher writes: a daily plan for each lesson, and a weekly plan that spreads the syllabus across the week so nothing is left to the last month.

Daily lesson plan — blank template (copy or photocopy)

Class: _____	**Subject:** _____
Topic: _____	**Date / Period:** _____
SLOs: Students will be able to _____	
Prior knowledge: _____	
Resources: _____	
Introduction (___ min): _____	
Presentation (___ min): _____	
Practice (___ min): _____	
Assessment: _____	
Homework: _____	
Reflection (after the period): _____	

Weekly plan — one subject, one week

Day	Topic / textbook pages	Main activity	Check / homework
Monday	New topic — first part	Presentation and guided practice	Oral questions
Tuesday	Topic continued	Practice from the exercise	Notebook check
Wednesday	Next topic	Activity or group work	Exit question
Thursday	Topic continued / revision	Independent practice	Short written task
Friday	Weekly test or revision	Test, then correction together	Record marks
Saturday	Catch-up and weak areas	Re-teach what the test showed	Plan next week

> **Plan on Friday, teach on Monday.** Writing the week's plans at the end of the previous week — even in short form — is the habit that most improves daily teaching, because materials and copies can be prepared in time.

Planning for Real Classrooms

Multigrade classes — two or three classes, one teacher

Many primary schools in our area have one teacher for two classes in one room. This is planned, not suffered:

- **Stagger the teaching.** Teach Class A directly for 15 minutes while Class B does written work set at the start; then change over. Never give both classes new teaching at the same moment.
- **Set self-running work.** Copying with a purpose, sums practice, drawing and labelling, and reading in pairs can run without the teacher. Plan this work the night before — it is half the multigrade plan.
- **Use shared openings where possible.** A story, a song or a general-knowledge topic can open for both classes together, then split into level-wise tasks.
- **Appoint monitors honestly.** A responsible senior student can distribute copies and keep a group on task, but teaching and checking stay with the teacher.

Large classes

- Plan pair work instead of individual answers: every child speaks, not only the front row.
- Use the board in sections — new work, examples, homework — so students can copy at different speeds without losing the lesson.
- Check notebooks by rows on different days, and say so in the plan, instead of promising to check sixty books in one period.
- Plan questions by name, spread across the room, so the same five hands do not answer everything.

When the plan fails — the backup plan

Periods are lost to rain, visitors, load-shedding, a school function, or a lesson that turns out to need ten more minutes. A planned teacher decides in advance:

- **What can be dropped?** Usually part of the practice — never the assessment of the SLO.
- **What carries forward?** Write the unfinished step at the top of the next day's plan, not in your memory.
- **Keep a filler ready.** A revision game, a dictation, or reading practice that fits any week, for the day the planned material finishes early or cannot be used.
- **If most of the class failed the check,** the plan for tomorrow is re-teaching in a different way — not moving on and hoping.

> **A plan is a guide, not a script.** Following the students' understanding is more important than finishing the page. But that freedom works only when there was a plan to depart from.

Assessment, Reflection, and Common Mistakes

Build the checking into the plan

Assessment in a daily plan is small and constant, not a monthly event. Three kinds, all planned in advance:

- **Before:** the prior-knowledge questions at the start tell you where today's lesson really begins.
- **During:** watching guided and independent practice — who is correct, who copies, who is stuck — is the most honest assessment a primary teacher has.
- **After:** the exit check matched to the SLO, the homework, and the weekly short test built from the week's SLOs.

Record the result in one line — for example, "24 of 31 met the SLO; re-teach carrying to the rest tomorrow" — otherwise the checking changes nothing.

The two-minute reflection

After the period, or at the end of the day, write two or three honest lines on the plan itself:

- Which step took longer or shorter than planned, and why?
- Which question or example worked best? Keep it for next year.
- Which students did not reach the SLO, and what is the first step of tomorrow's plan for them?
- What material was missing that I must prepare tonight?

Five common planning mistakes

Mistake	Fix
Writing topics, not outcomes	"Addition" is a topic. Write what students will do with it, and how you will check it.
No timings, so practice disappears	Give every step minutes. When time runs short, cut the teacher's talk, not the students' practice.
Planning only for the average student	Add one support task and one challenge task to every plan, in writing.
Homework that teaches new work	Homework repeats today's SLO. New learning belongs in class, where you can help.
Copying last year's plan unchanged	This year's class is different. Keep what reflection proved worked; rewrite what it did not.

One-Page Checklist and Quick Revision

Before every period — tick the plan

☐	My SLOs are written with action words, and I know how I will check each one.
☐	I have read the textbook pages myself and noted the difficult parts.
☐	My opening questions connect to what the class already knows.
☐	Every step has minutes, and practice has the biggest share.
☐	All materials — chart, flashcards, objects, copies — are in the room.
☐	I have one support task and one challenge task ready.
☐	My exit check matches the SLO exactly.
☐	Homework repeats today's learning and is written on the board.
☐	Yesterday's reflection is answered in today's plan.

Quick revision — questions and answers

Q1. What is an SLO?
A Student Learning Outcome: a statement of what students will be able to do by the end of the lesson, written with an action word so it can be checked.

Q2. Why decide the assessment before writing the teaching steps?
Because the steps then aim at a known target: every activity in the middle earns its place.

Q3. Which step should never be cut when time is short?
The assessment and the closure. Without them you do not know whether the SLO was achieved, and the lesson has no ending the students can remember.

Q4. How does planning change in a multigrade class?
The teacher staggers direct teaching between the classes and plans self-running work for the class not being taught at that moment.

Q5. What is the reflection part of a plan?
Two or three lines written after the period — what worked, what did not, and who needs help tomorrow. It is what turns one day's plan into a better next plan.

Q6. What makes homework correct in a daily plan?
It is short, repeats the day's SLO instead of introducing new work, and is explained in class before students leave.

> **Remember.** Ten minutes of honest planning saves the whole period. Plan the outcome first, give practice the most time — and write down what the checking told you.